Pink in cultures and traditions

Pink is a colour people long thought of as "obvious". Sweet, girlish, good. Behind its reputation, though, are **more stories about fashion, commerce and courage than about the colour itself**. Let us visit a few places and read them carefully.

This chapter therefore shows **two levels**. First, how pink is read in different **cultures**, and then how **traditional systems** look at it, using it as an image, not as instructions. What is verified history and what is later interpretation, I say in each part.

Pink in different cultures

Japan

In Japan pink is the colour of spring. The shade of cherry blossom is called **sakura-iro** and the traditional shade of peach blossom **momo-iro**. In spring people gather for hanami, sitting under the blossoming trees.

From a beauty that lasts only a few days. Pink here is not sweetness, but **a reminder that everything passes**.

A colour can become a celebration of a moment that cannot be stored away. It does not have to last to be worth something.

India

Jaipur is called the Pink City because in **1876** the whole of it was painted pink for a visit of the Prince of Wales. It has carried the name ever since. In Uttar Pradesh the women's group Gulabi Gang, meaning the pink gang, was formed in **2006**. Its members wear pink saris and protect women from violence.

From hospitality and from a need to be seen. The pink sari is a uniform that, according to the founder Sampat Pal, **commands respect** and gives a sense of community.

A colour can be a celebration as well as protection. Pink here is not weakness, but **a sign that this woman will not stay silent**.

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USA

In **1953**, at President Eisenhower's inauguration, his wife Mamie wore a pink gown, and pink became more firmly tied to femininity in the United States. A few decades later, in **1991**, the pink ribbon became a symbol of breast cancer awareness.

From fashion, advertising and public campaigns that gradually taught the colour to carry a message.

A colour can bring people together and unite them, but it can also **become overloaded with meaning**. The pink ribbon is so well known today that it easily overshadows how many women wear it from their own experience.

Germany and twentieth-century Europe

In the 1930s and 1940s, some prisoners in Nazi concentration camps, accused of homosexuality, had to wear a **pink triangle** on their clothing. It later became a symbol of the gay rights movement.

From a forced marking of people that turned into a sign of dignity and memory.

A colour can carry a history that raises no smile. **The same pink** can be playfulness and a memorial. It depends on the place where you meet it.

Pink in traditional systems

Every tradition looks at pink **a little differently**, but all take it seriously. It is an old symbolic language and an inspiration, not a healing manual.

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Traditional Chinese medicine

In the classical system of five elements the basic colours are green or blue-green, red, yellow, white and black. **Pink has no organ circuit of its own in it.** That is why we will not make a special healing colour out of it for the heart, lungs or hormones.

Red is linked in this system with fire and the heart. **We can take pink as a gentler form of red**, but that is already our colour metaphor, not a separate teaching of traditional Chinese medicine.

How it relates to pink. You can imagine fire as the joy of meeting, liveliness and the possibility of being with others. It does not always mean flames up to the ceiling. Pink is a fire that **does not have to burn at full strength**.

And what if I asked you now?

"What really warms me, and what only looks pretty?"

Warmth you do not have to keep handing out

Sometimes you do not need another celebration. You need to be with someone in front of whom you do not have to keep up a good mood at any cost. **A surrounding that reminds you of acceptance can be the gain**, not another demand.

Pleasant softness, or forced sweetness

Imagine two rooms. In one there is a muted pink bedspread, wood and room to sit. In the other pink walls, glossy decorations and a sign saying "Smile". Perhaps in the first your shoulders relax, and in the second you feel like leaving. These are not two diagnoses. Pink should **accompany you**, not keep you busy playing another role.

Traditional Chinese medicine uses the elements as an image. It is not a diagnosis and does not replace a doctor.

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Ayurveda

Ayurveda is an old Indian teaching about health. It describes a person by three types of "energy", the so-called doshas. Vata (air, restlessness), pitta (fire, intensity) and kapha (earth and water, heaviness). Colours are not assigned to the doshas uniformly in the classical texts, so here you read **modern interpretations**, not an old table.

How it relates to pink. Soft, light pink is often seen in contemporary approaches as gentle and calming. The exact assignments differ, though. For your own practice it is more useful to notice the difference between **soft pink and sharp fuchsia** than to call every shade calming.

Pitta

This describes a woman who is purposeful, quick and thorough, who flares up easily. A muted powder pink can feel cooling and soft. A sharp fuchsia may pour oil on the fire.

- **Powder and peach**
  Soft and calming, as an accent.
- **Beware of the sharp**
  A glowing glossy pink can be one more stimulus.

Vata

This describes a woman who is imaginative and quick, but restless and often cold. Warmer old rose and salmon can add warmth. **It is best to notice how you really feel in it.**

- **Old rose**
  Warm and earthy, without chill.
- **Evening and sleep**
  Gentle shades and warm light.

Kapha

This describes a woman who is calm, steady and patient, but who easily grows heavy. Too powdery and sweet may deepen the heaviness. The tradition advises **lively and warm colours**.

- **Raspberry and coral**
  Richer and livelier, as an accent.
- **Add movement**
  Orange or yellow as a counterweight. A scarf, a tablecloth.

What is useful for us is that Ayurveda works with qualities. Lightness and heaviness, warmth and cold, softness and sharpness. After a day full of demands you may enjoy a muted fabric and a simple surrounding. That is why I **am not writing a colour prescription** for a specific dosha.

An online test will not reliably determine your dosha. If you are more interested, consult a qualified Ayurvedic practitioner. It is not treatment.

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A Jungian view

Carl Gustav Jung, the Swiss psychiatrist, understood colours as symbols that have two layers. A personal one (what we have experienced with the colour) and one shared by all people (images that repeat across ages and cultures).

Jung did not describe pink as a colour of its own. What I write next is my own reflection in the spirit of his thinking, not his statement.

How it relates to pink. In the Jungian picture red is often the colour of feeling and life, white of purity and light. Pink, made of both, could be the colour of **feeling that is not afraid to be soft**. When you think about it, ask where you allow yourself to be gentle and where you do not.

What you can take from it. Jung did not want colours turned into a dictionary. **We always ask what it means for you.** The same pink can be joy for one woman and pressure for another. Jung's ideas about colours are a symbolic frame, not verified science.

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Feng shui

Feng shui is the Chinese art of arranging space so that it is good to live in. In some Western schools the southwest of the house map (bagua) is linked with relationships and partnership, and pink, red and white are used for it. Schools differ on this, so take it as one possibility.

Pink is like a peony

A few petals give a room softness, a full peony turns it into a sweet shop. Closeness is not the number of pink cushions.

Simple tips

- **Start with one piece**
  For example a cushion or a flower in a place where you will see it every day.
- **For every day**
  Powder, old rose and peach. Leave rich fuchsia for small accents.
- **Natural materials**
  Combine it with wood, linen and wool and with light colours.
- **Bedroom**
  Muted old rose in bedding or on part of a wall. Make sure it is not glossy and sugary.
- **Try fabric first**
  Before you repaint a room, try a throw or a larger sample and look at it in the morning and in the evening.
- **Watch the proportion**
  When there are too many pink things, taking one away helps more than adding another.

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What people say and what holds true

MYTH Pink is named after the rose.

TRUTH In Czech that fits, but the English "pink" is, according to dictionaries, derived from the name of a flower, the carnation. The colour took its name from the blossom, not from the rose.

MYTH Pink in the bedroom will bring love.

TRUTH Feng shui links the southwest with partnership and some consultants recommend pink there. Recommendations differ and a colour guarantees nothing. How you sleep in the bedroom will help more.

MYTH The sweeter the pink, the more tenderness.

TRUTH A very sweet or loud pink can tire you. Powder, peach or dusty pink have a softer and more grown-up look.

What pink goes well with

- **Green**
  Flower and leaves. Muted shades look more natural.
- **Indigo and dark blue**
  Greater depth and contrast.
- **Ochre, terracotta and brown**
  A more earthy whole.
- **Cream, linen and wood**
  A gentler, less over-sweet impression.
- **Red**
  A striking related pair, give one of the colours more space.
- **Black and gold**
  A sharper graphic look. Gold in excess recalls a shop window more than a home.

Elements

- **Fire**
  Pink is its gentle form. Make sure it does not outweigh the rest.
- **Wood**
  Green and wood ground it.
- **Earth**
  Clay and linen soften the sweet impression.
- **Water**
  Blue and dark tones cool and deepen it.

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Feng shui room by room

Living room

What works. An old-rose armchair or a picture can soften a grey or navy room. A green plant and natural materials bring the whole closer to a garden than a sweet shop.

What to watch for. A sharp pink sofa that disturbs in the evening. First try a muted throw, you do not have to order new furniture at once.

A simple tip. Start with one thing. It is easier to tell whether you missed a warmer colour, or whether the light needed changing and things needed taking away.

Kitchen and dining room

What works. Pink on ceramics, a tea towel or part of the furniture. Next to wood and a simple base it feels lived-in.

What to watch for. A large sweet surface without wood can feel like a confectioner's. A kitchen is mainly meant to be used.

A simple tip. Try a pink mug or tablecloth and leave the rest light.

Bedroom

What works. Muted pink, old rose or a soft pink-beige tone in bedding, a throw or on part of a wall. A softer and more personal impression, especially when your bedroom feels cold.

What to watch for. Glossy pink surfaces and too many decorations. If you live with a partner, look for a form pleasant to you both. A bedroom is not proof of who won the colour referendum.

A simple tip. Combine pink with linen, cream and wood. Replace part of the textiles with a calmer base.

Children's room

What works. If a child loves pink, they can have it. But they do not have to get a pink floor, furniture, ceiling and future.

What to watch for. The whole set in one shade. Strong shades are easier to change in pictures and textiles than in furniture.

A simple tip. Leave room for other colours and for a change of taste. A room that can grow with the child.

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Study and studio

What works. Muted pink on part of a wall, in a picture or on upholstery can be personal and unobtrusive. Pleasant does not mean unprofessional.

What to watch for. A striking fuchsia that keeps drawing the eye. Put it outside the main line of sight.

A simple tip. You do not have to remove pink because of an idea that serious work may only happen between grey and beige.

Hallway and bathroom

What works. In a bathroom you can easily try pink on towels. In a hallway a flower, a picture or a rug is enough as a first greeting.

What to watch for. For make-up and judging your skin keep ordinary good lighting, not a pink light that tints everything. Otherwise you will see your make-up only outdoors.

A simple tip. Try one soft piece and look at it both in the morning and in the evening.

And try answering now

“Why do I want pink at home? What should it bring me, warmth, playfulness, or a feeling of being welcome?”

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